Jewish Federations of North America

February 2026

Supporting Israelis with Disabilities

A Strategic Guide for Jewish Federations

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A Note From The Chair

Dear Reader,

It has been my privilege to chair this Task Force and learn from so many thoughtful colleagues and dedicated individuals in Israel. I invite you to use this report as a living resource - a starting point for conversation and collaboration across our system. The needs in Israel evolve rapidly, and we are strongest when we learn from one another's experiences. I encourage you to explore the recommendations in this report, share which organizations and approaches you are considering, and connect with peers to consider ways to amplify our impact. Together, we can align our collective generosity with strategic action to help build a more inclusive Israel in which everyone has the opportunity to thrive.

Susie Sorkin

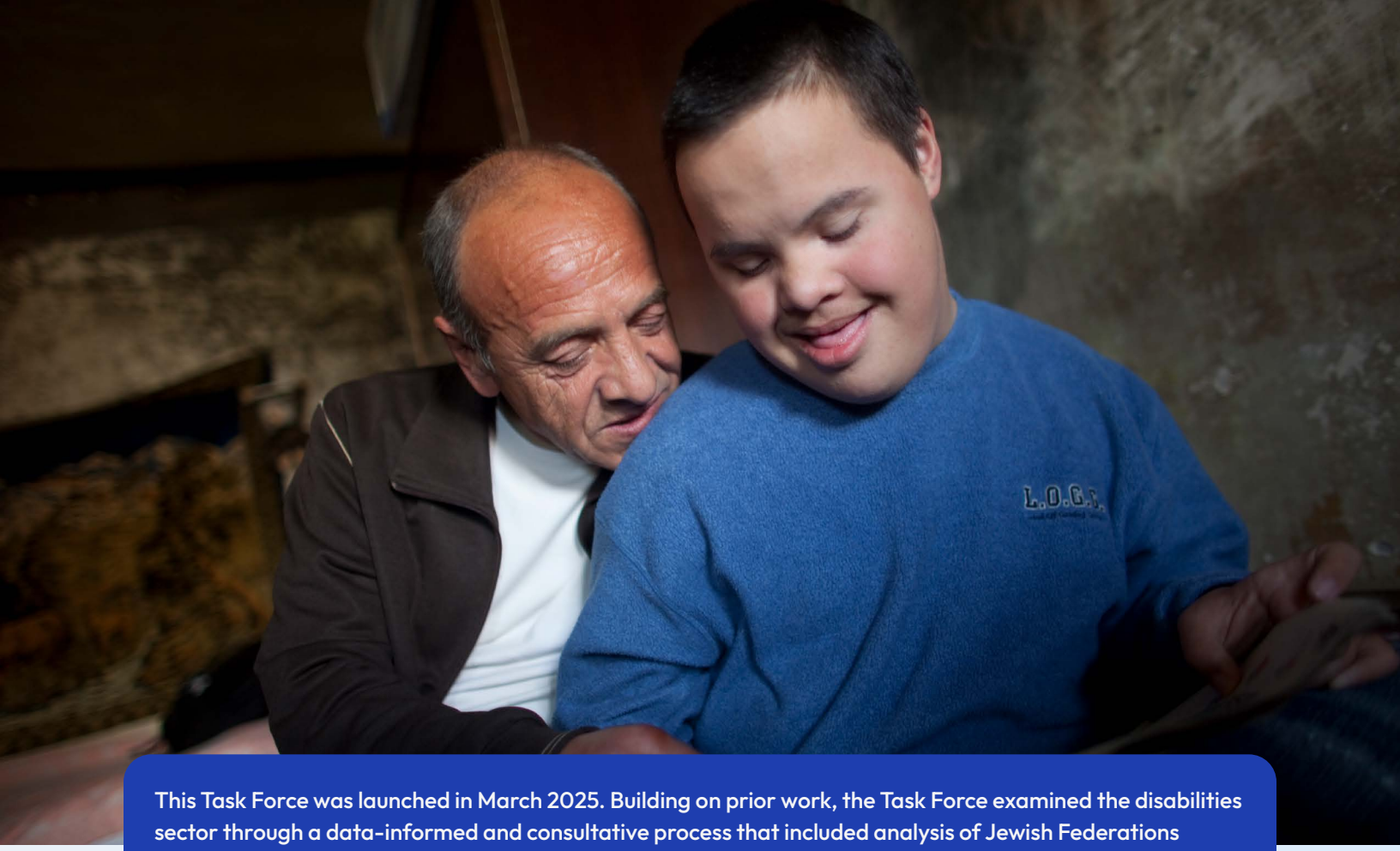
Chair, Designated Allocations Task Force

Executive Summary

This report presents the Jewish Federations of North America's Israel & Overseas Committee Designated Allocations Task Force's guide and recommendations for supporting people in Israel with disabilities. It is designed to serve as a practical, strategic resource for Jewish Federations seeking to strengthen their impact through informed, values-driven grantmaking in this key field.

Up to 20% of Israel's population—around two million people—live with disabilities, encompassing psychosocial, physical, sensory, developmental, learning, and intellectual disabilities, and chronic illnesses, across all sectors of Israeli society. Israel has established a strong legislative framework supporting the rights and inclusion of people with disabilities, however, uneven implementation, regional disparities, bureaucratic complexity, and persistent gaps in services limit the realization of these rights in practice.

The urgency of this issue has intensified since the October 7, 2023, attack on Israel and the ensuing war. Tens of thousands of Israelis have sustained permanent physical and psychosocial disabilities, increasing demand for services. This moment has also heightened public awareness and created an opportunity for philanthropy to complement government investment, strengthen nonprofit capacity, and accelerate systemic change.



This Task Force was launched in March 2025. Building on prior work, the Task Force examined the disabilities sector through a data-informed and consultative process that included analysis of Jewish Federations allocations from 2021–2024, meetings with government officials, academics, nonprofit leaders, advocates, and people with disabilities, and an in-depth review of select nonprofits in the field.

The report recognizes that the Israeli government is the primary funder of disability services through multiple ministries and authorities, most often delivered either as direct disability pensions or via contracts with nonprofit organizations. Philanthropic funding plays a distinct and essential role: filling gaps where government funding does not exist, supporting innovation and pilot programs, investing in infrastructure, advancing advocacy and access to rights, and strengthening organizational capacity.

Based on this analysis, the report offers guiding principles for Jewish Federations funding in this field, including:

- **Prioritizing** programs not funded by government
- **Supporting** innovation with pathways to government adoption
- **Investing** in capital and human resources to maximize public funding
- **Increasing** attention to underserved populations

The report recommends eighteen vetted nonprofit organizations, alongside continued strong support for our historic partner JDC's disabilities work through Israel Unlimited (JDC-IU). Together, these organizations span a wide range of disabilities, populations, and interventions, while all advancing a shared vision of inclusion, independence, and dignity.

Ultimately, this report affirms that Jewish Federations are positioned to play a catalytic role in building a more accessible and inclusive Israel by aligning philanthropic resources with strategic priorities and trusted partners to help ensure that Israelis with disabilities are full participants in all aspects of society.

Introduction

The Jewish Federations of North America are committed to strengthening the well-being of people with disabilities and promoting inclusion, as part of our mission to build flourishing Jewish communities worldwide. In Israel, major advances have been made in recent years which impact the rights, services, benefits, and accessibility for Israelis with disabilities, yet significant gaps still remain. Jewish Federations have an opportunity to leverage this momentum and contribute to building a more accessible Israel for all.

This report summarizes the work of the Designated Funding Task Force which was launched under the Israel & Overseas Committee in late 2022. The Task Force seeks to support Jewish Federations' overseas work as it evolves to a more data-informed approach by examining philanthropic fields supported by Jewish Federations, mapping the needs and organizations addressing them, suggesting strategic directions, and sharing allocation recommendations that can help guide investment to expand Jewish Federations' impact.

The Task Force chose to examine support for the long-term integration of Ethiopian Israelis into Israeli society in its first iteration with results published in 2023 and opted next to explore the needs of Israelis with disabilities which have grown considerably due to the high number of injuries suffered since October 7, 2023.

Our Goal

Develop a comprehensive resource for Jewish Federations that introduces leading nonprofits supporting Israelis with disabilities, outlines strategic funding priorities, and provides allocation recommendations designed to enhance Jewish Federations' impact through strategic grantmaking.

Background Information

Approximately 20% of Israel's 10 million residents live with disabilities, spanning every ethnic, religious, and socioeconomic sector. This population includes people with physical, sensory, intellectual, developmental, and psychosocial disabilities.

Many people with disabilities are officially recognized by the government and eligible to receive corresponding services, while others are not. Due to the broad definition of disabilities and individuals' diverse experiences, it is important to recognize that not all people with disabilities require special services or interventions, and people can experience multiple types of disabilities simultaneously.

For additional resources, please click here.

Legislative Progress

Israel has strong legislative foundations that support people with disabilities, including:

1998	2000	2002
Equal Rights for Persons with Disabilities Law	Rehabilitation in the Community of Persons with Mental Disabilities Law	Inclusion Amendment to the Special Education Law

2012	2022	Additional Legislation
Ratification of the UN Convention of the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (CRPD)	Welfare Services for People with Disabilities Law	Employment integration and accessibility of public spaces and services

Ongoing Challenges

For the last few decades, promoting independent or semi-independent community-based housing as an alternative to institution-based care has been a major priority. Yet, nearly 20,000 Israelis with still live in closed institutions including hostels and hospital-type settings, lacking access to community-based alternatives such as shared apartments. The government has committed to advancing community-based frameworks in accordance with the UN convention and all organizations recommended by the Task Force pursue that approach.

Despite the strong legislative backdrop, implementation remains uneven across regions and subpopulations. Disparities persist for Israelis with disabilities, and those disparities are exacerbated among Arab citizens of Israel, people experiencing poverty, and those struglling to navigate Israel's complex bureaucracy.

Israelis with disabilities will likely have to interface with many different government authorities throughout their lifetime to access the rights and benefits guaranteed to them by law. A non-exhaustive list includes:

- National Insurance Institute (Israeli equivalent of U.S. Social Security Administration)
- Local Authorities
- Ministry of Welfare and Social Affairs
- Ministry of Health
- Health Management Organizations (Kupot Holim)
- Ministry of Education
- Ministry of Labor
- Ministry of Defense (for veterans)
- Ministry of Justice (Commission for Equal Rights of Persons with Disabilities)
- Ministry of Transportation

Israel's thriving nonprofit sector plays a critical role in providing government-funded services, filling gaps with philanthropic support, driving innovation, importing new approaches from abroad, and advocating for and amplifying the voices of people with disabilities.

Several hundred registered nonprofits operate in the disabilities field in Israel, ranging from small community-based organizations to large umbrella organizations with national reach and access to significant public funds. Some organizations focus on specific types of disabilities or interventions, while others advance the field overall.

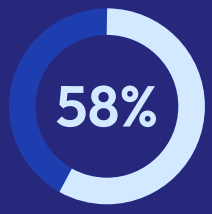
October 7th: Impact on Israelis with Disabilities

Sadly, the attacks of October 7, 2023 and the ensuing war have **left many Israelis living with permanent disabilities,** heightening the focus of Jewish Federations on this critical area. Since October 7, Israel has seen a sharp rise in the number of individuals affected by physical and psychosocial disabilities, particularly among security personnel.

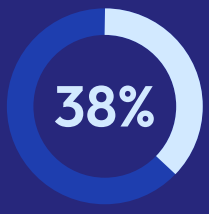
As of December 2025:

20,000+
soldiers wounded since Oct. 7

80,000
total wounded veterans from all conflicts



wounded soldiers experienced emotional harm



wounded soldiers dealing exclusively with PTSD

1,000
new disability claims filed monthly

$2.5B
annual government budget to treat wounded soldiers

The **increase in both physical and psychosocial disabilities creates urgent demand** for rehabilitative services, long-term care, support systems, and inclusive social infrastructure. It has also brought greater public awareness of and empathy for the challenges faced by disabled Israelis and **underscores the opportunity for philanthropic engagement and capacity** building among nonprofits serving people with disabilities.

Note: This report focuses on Israelis with chronic disabilities but does not include medical rehabilitation or recovery from physical or emotional injury.

Current Funding Landscape

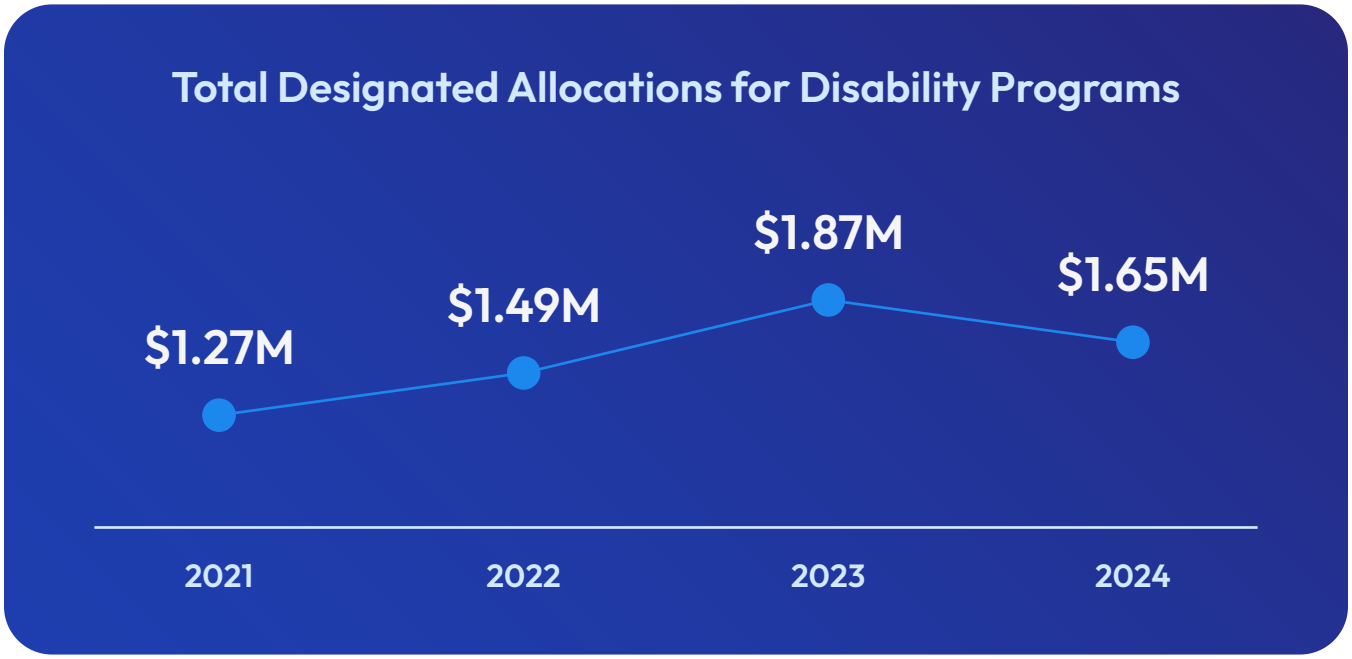
The Israeli government is the biggest funder in the field, distributing billions of dollars per year in disability benefits payments and providing services via nonprofit contractors. These funds come through various government ministries and authorities, as previously noted. Many NGOs receive substantial government funding for service delivery, and have relatively small budgets from philanthropy. Yet, these organizations rely on philanthropy to fill service gaps, develop innovative programs, and help cover capital development costs for facilities.

The Ministry of Welfare and Social Affairs' Disabilities Administration provides services through local welfare departments and contracted organizations, implementing the 2022 Welfare Services for People with Disabilities Law with a budget of $671 million over five years plus $135 million annually. Operating through four divisions which monitor implementation, work is divided according to: assessment, recognition, community, and residential services. The Ministry follows the principle "nothing about us without us," shifting from services driven primarily as a result of a medical diagnosis to a person-centered approach based on individual needs, preferences, and abilities.

Jewish Federations Allocations

The Task Force based its work on an analysis of designated funding from Jewish Federations for programming for people with disabilities during the years 2021-2024, excluding emergency funding. Significant allocations to disability nonprofits also flowed from both the collective Israel Emergency Response Committee and individual Jewish Federations, but those allocations supported emergency projects and are outside the scope of this report. Additional funding is also directed by individual donors through Federations, but that funding is also not presented here.

For more information on emergency allocations that supported people with disabilities in Israel after October 7, click here. For more information on Jewish Federations emergency allocations in the field of resilience building and mental health, click here.



These Jewish Federations allocated funds to organizations serving Israelis with disabilities in 2023-2024:

- Ann Arbor
- Atlanta
- Birmingham
- Boston
- Broward County
- Canada (all)
- Charlotte
- Chicago
- Cincinnati
- Cleveland
- Dallas
- Detroit
- Hartford
- Heart of New Jersey
- Kansas City
- MetroWest New Jersey
- Miami
- Milwaukee
- Nashville
- Nevada
- New York
- Northern New Jersey
- Omaha
- Philadelphia
- Phoenix
- Pittsburgh
- Portland
- Sarasota-Manatee
- Seattle
- South Palm Beach County
- Southern New Jersey
- Washington DC
- Western Connecticut
- Youngstown

Core and Designated Allocations to JDC

In addition to these designated allocations, Jewish Federations are primary funders of the American Jewish Joint Distribution Committee's (JDC) ongoing operations through the significant core dollars provided on an annual basis, supporting all its activities in Israel and around the world. JDC-Israel Unlimited (JDC-IU) is JDC's division fostering independence and autonomy for people with disabilities in Israel. JDC achieves notable leverage of Federation core funding primarily from the Israeli government, enabling national reach and impact. Read more about JDC-IU's work in a dedicated section below.

In 2023, 2.4% of $29.5 million core dollars allocated to JDC from Jewish Federations supported JDC-IU ($713,414).

In 2024, 3.4% of $32.5 million core dollars allocated to JDC from Jewish Federations supported JDC-IU ($1,098,277).

In addition to core allocations from across the Jewish Federation system, these Jewish Federations allocated additional grants directly to JDC-IU (mostly for emergency needs): Baltimore, Cape Cod, Hartford, Houston, Kalamazoo, Los Angeles, Minneapolis, South Palm Beach County, and Toronto.

Extensive efforts were made to collect complete and accurate data. If a Federation was left off this list, the omission was unintentional. Please contact Graeme.Campbell@JewishFederations.org to correct the error.

Source data shows Canadian Federations' allocations collectively.

Jewish Federations' Historic Partners

Jewish Federations allocate annually to the core budget of three historic partner organizations, The Jewish Agency for Israel, the American Jewish Joint Distribution Committee (JDC), and World ORT. The Jewish Agency for Israel and World ORT each include people with disabilities across their programming but do not operate specific programs for this population and are therefore outside of the scope of the Task Force. Additionally, Jewish Federations/UIA allocates higher education scholarships annually to students with physical disabilities and to wounded IDF veterans from endowment funds in partnership with The Jewish Agency.

JDC

JDC runs extensive programs specifically for people with disabilities, supported by Jewish Federations, which are highlighted in this section. Core allocations support all of JDC's activities in Israel and in Jewish communities around the world. In 2009, JDC-Israel Unlimited (JDC-IU) was founded as a partnership between JDC-Israel and the Israeli government. Its mission is to enable people with disabilities to live independently, improve their quality of life, and promote a culture of inclusion in Israeli society.

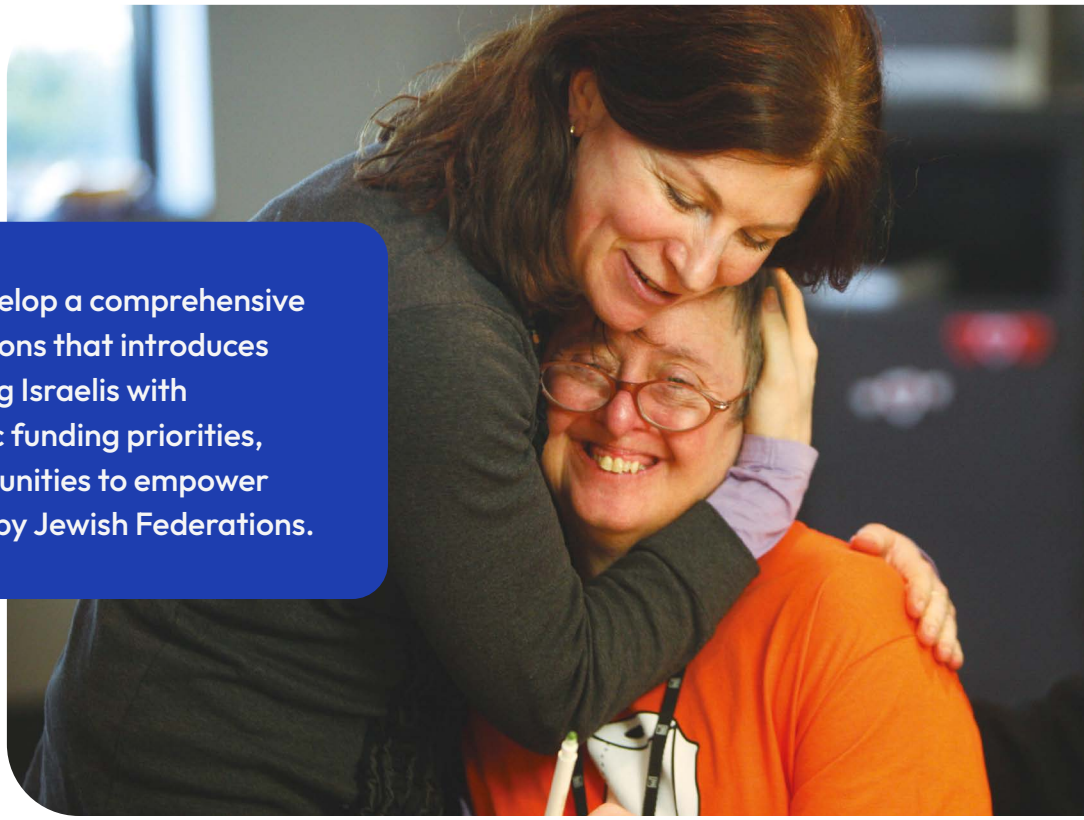
JDC-IU is a convener–bringing together the national government, local authorities, and other nonprofits to maximize the use of resources and improve organizational capacities. JDC-IU also develops programmatic and policy-driven solutions to address systemic challenges to effective delivery of social services to Israelis with disabilities. It also disseminates original research and insights and incorporates best practices and knowledge gathered from around the world. Throughout all its initiatives JDC-IU leverages technology and data-driven tools.

JDC-IU is currently engaged in four multi-year, large-scale initiatives:

- **Independent Housing in the Community**
- **Personalization of Services**
- **Community-based Rehabilitation**
- **Commitments and Opportunities***

*Includes work with the private sector, technology innovators, and digital literacy for people with disabilities.

Task Force Methodology



The Task Force aimed to develop a comprehensive resource for Jewish Federations that introduces leading nonprofits supporting Israelis with disabilities, outlines strategic funding priorities, and provides funding opportunities to empower impactful future allocations by Jewish Federations.

To develop an understanding of the field including areas of need, members of the Task Force, its Chair, and Jewish Federations' professional staff conducted meetings with government officials, academics, communal leaders, nonprofits, and Israelis with disabilities.

Through an analysis of recent Jewish Federation allocations and meetings with experts, the Task Force identified dozens of organizations working in the field. Twenty-two national-scale nonprofits were selected for intensive review based on their potential for systemic change.

Task Force members worked in pairs, meeting with three to four organizations each. In addition, Jewish Federations' historic partner organization, JDC, presented its relevant activities to the full Task Force.

Prior to meetings, organizations completed a detailed questionnaire on their activities, programs, governance, partnerships, and finance to inform Task Force members in advance. After meeting each organization, Task Force members used 12 criteria to "score" them. This process was overseen by the Task Force Chair to ensure consistency. Task Force pairs regularly reported back to the full Task Force to share learnings and impressions of the organizations they met.

Recommendations

As noted above, the Israeli government has chosen to deliver most disability services through contracts with nonprofit organizations (and some for-profit providers) with various government authorities issuing tenders worth billions of dollars annually. This has created a funding landscape in which many of the leading organizations receive most of their funding from the government. Consequently, the major opportunities for philanthropy in this field can be categorized as those which can enhance the effectiveness and impact of public funding and to fill in the inevitable gaps that remain.

Many of the nonprofits in the disabilities field offer a broad range of services and programs for the populations that they serve, with some focusing on specific disabilities or age groups and others serving all disabilities or ages. Each area has its own specific challenges, and the Task Force did not attempt to establish a hierarchy of need between different types of disabilities.

The following recommendations can help guide Federations when choosing where to allocate funding in this field:

Support disability programming that is not funded by government, including accessibility, advocacy,* public awareness, technology, accessing rights, research, and more.

For nonprofits providing government-funded services, Jewish Federations should focus on programs that:

- Develop new or innovative approaches undertaken by organizations that have a demonstrated pathway for pilot programs being adopted by the government if successful.
- Invest in physical infrastructure (capital) or human resources (training, professional recruitment, and retention) that can help maximize the impact of government funding.
- Provide additional services only in fields that the government does not fund and where a clear need exists.
- Consider prioritizing programs that support underserved populations, including adults - who may receive less focus than children or seniors - minorities, and other populations.

*North American public charities are required to avoid political intervention activities, like supporting a particular candidate or political party, and there are limitations to how much of their activities can fund lobbying for specific legislation.

Recommended Organizations

The following 18 organizations were vetted by Task Force members and determined to be professional organizations, delivering impactful services and with the capability to work with Jewish Federations to allocate and direct resources effectively. Collectively, these organizations cover a wide range of disabilities, provide a very broad range of services, and address all the key challenges in the disabilities field. Furthermore, most individual donors with an interest in supporting a specific disability or type of response will be able to find an organization relevant to their interest from this group.

In addition, continued support for JDC's Israel Unlimited both through Jewish Federations' annual undesignated allocations and directed grants is strongly encouraged.

Many organizations do important work beyond these focus areas. These priorities don't diminish other efforts, and Jewish Federations will continue supporting diverse organizations based on their goals.

For further information on this topic or help connecting with the organizations listed in this report, contact Graeme Campbell at Graeme.Campbell@JewishFederations.org.

Access Israel

Access Israel's mission is to promote accessibility and inclusion, achieve full integration, and improve quality of life for people with disabilities and the elderly in all aspects of life. The organization works to ensure accessibility in public spaces and accessibility of services in public organizations and private businesses; educates and raises awareness; advances policy, legislation, and enforcement of accessibility laws; creates innovative solutions and incorporates technology for independent living and inclusion; and promotes accessibility in emergency preparedness and response. The organization has around 100 staff members and an annual budget of close to $10 million.

Bizchut

Bizchut's mission is to ensure that people with disabilities can fully exercise their rights to dignity, equality, autonomy, and freedom. The organization advances rights for people with all types of disabilities, in every aspect of life, promoting equality, respect, and full inclusion into Israeli society. Bizchut's five core focus areas are independent living in the community, fair employment, participation in policymaking ("nothing about us without us"), elimination of the use of restraints in institutional settings, and access to justice. It has had major successes over more than 30 years, with experience and credibility in the eyes of senior civil servants, elected officials, academics, and nonprofits. Bizchut receives no government funding in order to maintain its independence in promoting social change that benefits all Israelis with disabilities. Its main challenge is directing public attention to people with disabilities especially during times of national crisis and war in Israel when attention is elsewhere – and which are precisely the times when people with disabilities face heightened risks. Another challenge is raising the necessary philanthropic funds when donors often prioritize direct aid and programmatic interventions over systemic change, which is a long-term, complex process. Bizchut has eight staff members and an annual budget of around $600,000.

Tamar, 63, has been deaf since birth. She uses a cochlear implant and a hearing aid; her spouse is also deaf. When missile alerts sound during the night, Tamar and her husband cannot hear the sirens. They sleep through life-threatening danger. At times, their daughters stay over just so someone can wake them when a rocket alert goes off. On Tamar's behalf, Bizchut filed a petition to the Supreme Court demanding that the government provide accessible means for people with hearing disabilities to receive alerts during missile sirens. The government committed to act and launched a pilot of accessible emergency alert devices - steps that can save lives.

Kesher - Connecting Special Families

Kesher's mission is to promote the rights and welfare of families of children and adults with special needs, believing that empowered and involved parents and families are the source of strength and hope for their children. The organization provides support for families with children and adults with all types of disabilities, from all population groups in Israel: Jews, Arabs, religious, orthodox, and secular, in all regions of the country. Kesher provides parental guidance, a center for accessing rights and benefits, case management, and emotional support. It developed a unique program which supports siblings of people with disabilities. Kesher also operates support groups, encourages grassroots social change, advocates with the government, and raises awareness. Kesher has nine staff members and an annual budget of around $750,000.

Advocacy & Family Support

General Disability Service Providers

AlManarah

AlManarah's mission is to empower people with disabilities in Arab society by promoting inclusion, accessibility, and equal opportunities. Based in northern Israel, AlManarah creates programs in the fields of education, employment, and culture for Arabic-speakers with disabilities. The organization promotes accessibility and awareness by working to change public perceptions, advocating for equal rights, and helping people with disabilities ensure their voices are heard. AlManarah House in Nazareth is the center of the organization's activities, and it also provides digital resources such as ArabCast Books, reaching users internationally. Its main challenges are the systemic barriers and stigma toward people with disabilities, particularly in Arab society, lack of accessibility in public institutions, and limited financial resources needed to expand programs in underserved Arabic-speaking communities. AlManarah has 10 staff members and an annual budget of around $1.5 million.

Beit Issie Shapiro

Beit Issie Shapiro's mission is to build a more inclusive society by advancing opportunities and rights for people with disabilities in Israel and around the world through an "innovate-research-scale" approach. From its center in Ra'anana, the organization creates new solutions to fill service gaps, tests and refines them, and then takes proven models to scale through training, knowledge sharing, and policy advocacy. It operates across all types of disabilities and ages, providing services such as hydrotherapy, early childhood intervention, higher education opportunities, and more. Its main challenges are balancing immediate service delivery with systemic change and preserving its global activities despite increasingly negative attitudes toward Israel. Beit Issie Shapiro has 290 staff members and an annual budget of around $13 million.

Chimes Israel

Chimes Israel's mission is to improve the quality of life of people with disabilities by helping them use their own abilities and skills to lead lives of dignity, independence, and community participation. Chimes develops and delivers innovative rehabilitative, educational, therapeutic, and employment programs in 26 centers for all ages and for individuals from all backgrounds. The organization developed an "under-one-roof" model that integrates diagnosis, therapy, education, daycare, and parental guidance in one center. It operates multidisciplinary early childhood centers, pioneered the "individual habilitation plans" approach, advances empowerment for women and girls, and developed trauma-informed expertise during the war, especially with its strong presence in Ashkelon. Its main challenges are funding programs which are not government-supported, such as emotional health, trauma-awareness, and family support, recruiting and retaining skilled staff, and meeting infrastructure challenges, especially fortifying centers with safe rooms. Chimes has more than 600 full and part-time staff members and an annual budget of more than $25 million.

Israel Elwyn

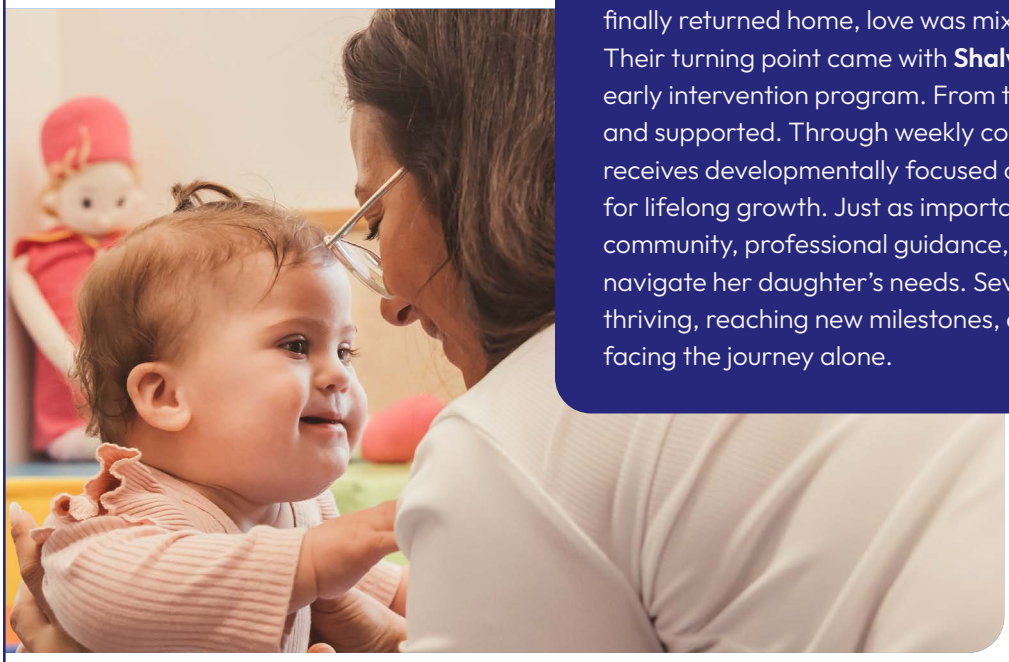
Israel Elwyn's mission is to develop and provide a wide array of supports for people with disabilities, while constantly striving for excellence of service and the creation of a just society. The organization serves people from all backgrounds and all ages across multiple categories of disabilities. Israel Elwyn provides its services through governmental tenders and pilots programs which government later adopts and scales. The organization pioneered a supported employment model to integrate individuals with intellectual disabilities in the competitive job market, rather than in sheltered employment programs, as well as a unique transitional program for high school students. It operates a program for young people who volunteer for military or national service, day centers, supported living frameworks, self-advocacy initiatives, and more. Its main challenges are developing new accessible vocational training courses, and fundraising for non-government funded enhancements for beneficiaries such as innovative equipment, staff training, and quality-of-life upgrades. Israel Elwyn has 1,400 staff members and an annual budget of more than $70 million.

Kivunim

Kivunim's mission is to realize a vision of an equal, respectful, and safe reality for young adults with disabilities. The organization, based in the Western Galilee region of northern Israel, promotes independence and self-realization for people with a wide range of disabilities. It develops programs in independent living, employment, education, and health that help participants and their families live according to their personal goals. Kivunim pioneered programs in training for independent living which have been adopted by the Ministry of Welfare and Social Affairs and recently established new Life Preparatory Programs (mechinot) in new geographies. Its main challenges are the impact of the war on northern Israel, government funding gaps, bureaucracy, limited housing options for independent living, and shortages of qualified staff. Kivunim has 115 staff members and an annual budget of more than $7 million.

Shalva

Shalva's mission is to provide transformative care for individuals with disabilities, empower their families, and promote social inclusion. The organization provides therapeutic, educational, recreational, and vocational programs from its state-of-the-art facilities in Jerusalem. Shalva offers a wide range of programs: early intervention for infants and their parents, community-based apartments for adults practicing independent living, sports and wellness activities, preschool, after school programs, vocational training, social enterprises like the Shalva Café and Shalva Band, and more. Shalva's center is also equipped to be a national crisis center, including capacity to host evacuees. Its main challenges are raising additional resources to reach more beneficiaries and expanding geographically beyond the greater Jerusalem area. Shalva has 500 staff members and an annual budget of more than $25 million.



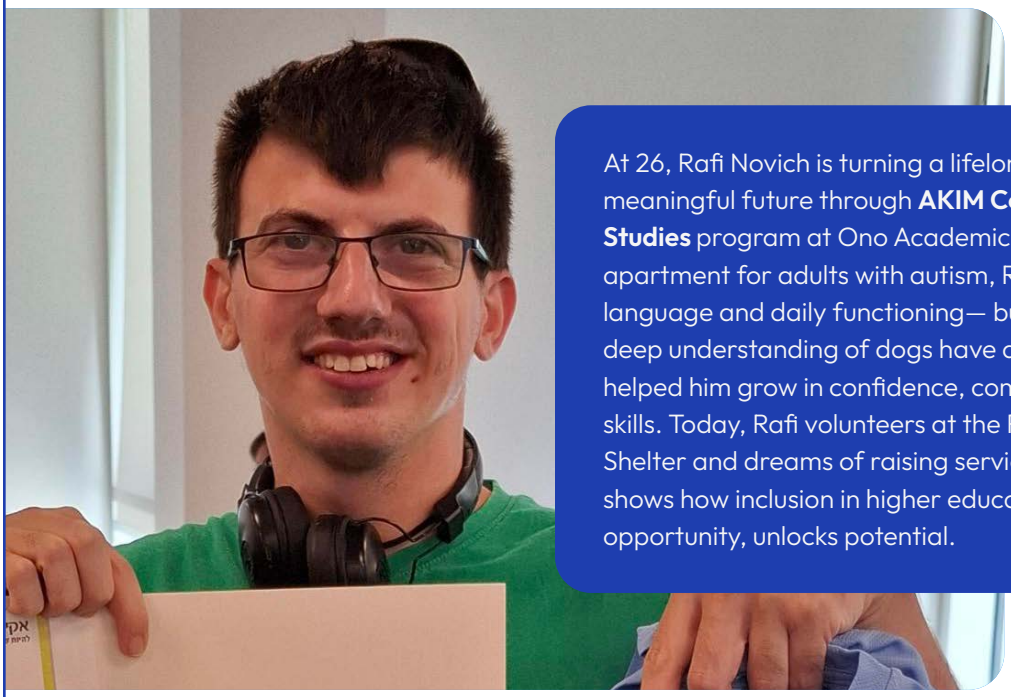
Yuli and Gal arrived at the hospital expecting a routine birth. Instead, their daughter Tahel was born with Down syndrome, followed by months of serious medical challenges. When they finally returned home, love was mixed with fear and uncertainty. Their turning point came with **Shalva's Me and My Mommy** early intervention program. From the first call, Yuli felt guided and supported. Through weekly comprehensive therapies, Tahel receives developmentally focused care, setting the foundation for lifelong growth. Just as importantly, Yuli found a supportive community, professional guidance, and the confidence to navigate her daughter's needs. Seven months later, Tahel is thriving, reaching new milestones, and her family is no longer facing the journey alone.

SHEKEL

SHEKEL's mission is to enable people with disabilities to live independent self-determined lives within the general community, providing equal opportunity and respect regardless of religion, race, or background. The organization develops and operates community-based services in housing, employment, leisure, and accessibility and provides emotional and therapeutic support. SHEKEL's strength is its continuum of care and person-centered services within the community, including multi-disability responses for a wide range of needs. Its main challenges are fundraising to bridge the gap between government funding and actual costs of high-quality care, recruiting and retaining staff, and maintaining professional and technological standards. SHEKEL has 850 staff members and an annual budget of more than $35 million.

AKIM Israel

AKIM's mission is to drive the inclusive participation of individuals with intellectual disabilities in all facets of Israeli society through a variety of programs for participants of all ages. The organization works to promote inclusion in society, support independent living solutions, advocate for rights and accessibility, and strengthen family support systems. AKIM works in all areas of Israel and serves individuals with intellectual disabilities and their families from all backgrounds. Its biggest challenge is making de-institutionalization a reality, due to Israel's high rent and purchase prices for apartments, difficulty recruiting and retaining professional staff, and expanding facilities in Israel's geographic periphery. The organization has more than 1,000 staff members and an annual budget of more than $60 million.



At 26, Rafi Novich is turning a lifelong love of dogs into a meaningful future through **AKIM College's Equal in Canine Studies** program at Ono Academic College. Living in a community apartment for adults with autism, Rafi has faced challenges with language and daily functioning— but his patience, diligence, and deep understanding of dogs have always stood out. The program helped him grow in confidence, communication, and professional skills. Today, Rafi volunteers at the Rishon LeZion Municipal Dog Shelter and dreams of raising service and therapy dogs. His story shows how inclusion in higher education, when matched with opportunity, unlocks potential.

OTI

OTI's mission is to provide equal access to treatment for every child in Israel diagnosed with autism spectrum disorder regardless of background or location. The organization operates nationally through an integrated approach across fields of care from early intervention to vocational training for adults. OTI sets high standards of care through tailored, interdisciplinary diagnostic and therapeutic responses across its more than 500 frameworks and prioritizes innovation, training for professional, monitoring, and evaluation. Its main challenge is retention of qualified professional staff due to salary competition from new commercial service providers. The organization has more than 2,300 staff members and an annual budget of more than $95 million.

Physical Disabilities

ILAN

ILAN's mission is to enable people with physical disabilities to live meaningful, quality lives. The umbrella organization was established in 1952 and works with physically disabled people of all ages and backgrounds across Israel, providing health and human services and infrastructure for integration into society. ILAN's strengths are sports programming, rights realization, and creation of long-term physical rehabilitation solutions in the community. ILAN operates more than twenty centers nationwide, including the Israel ParaSport Center. Its main challenge is reaching new potential beneficiaries and tackling bureaucracy. ILAN has 500 staff members and an annual budget of more than $30 million.

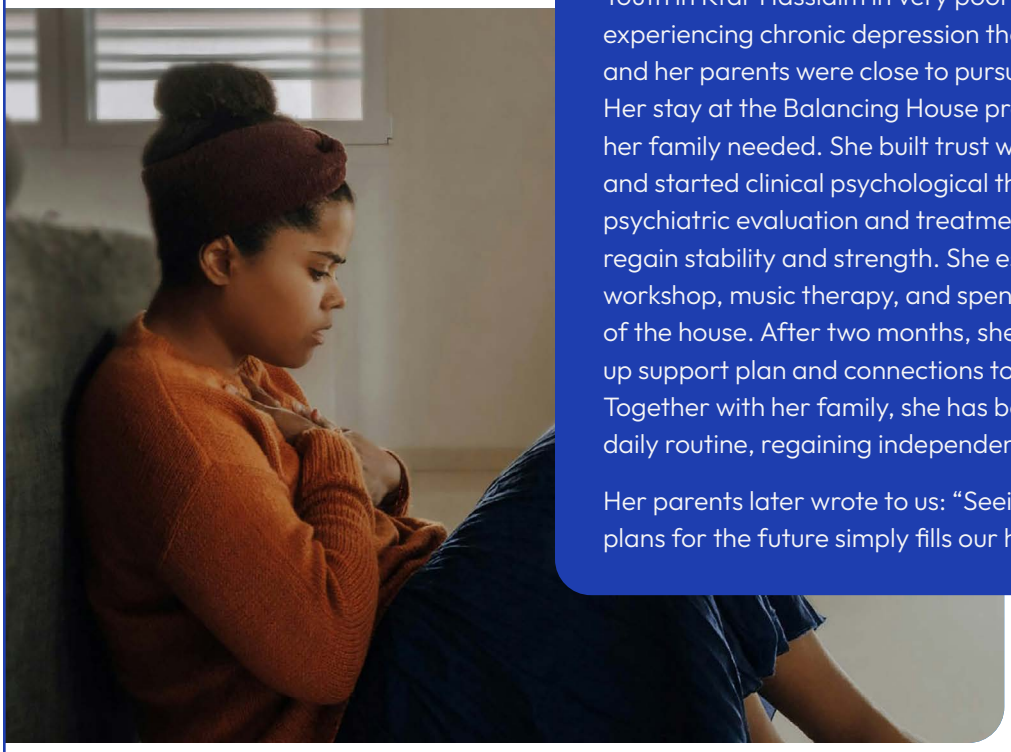
Credit: Razi Livnat

Inbal Pezaro's journey is a testament to what opportunity can unlock. Paralyzed from birth, Inbal entered the **ILAN Sports Center** in Haifa at age five for rehabilitation—and found her future in the water. Within years she was competing nationally, then internationally, representing Israel in four Paralympic Games and winning silver and bronze medals on the world stage. Today, Inbal is not only a Paralympic medalist, but an educator, activist, and mentor—lifting the next generation of athletes by showing what's possible when belief, support, and determination come together.

Psychosocial Disabilities

Enosh

Enosh's mission is to promote recovery, social inclusion, and rights of people with psychosocial disabilities and their families. Established in 1978, Enosh is Israel's largest mental health organization with 85 locations, providing rehabilitation services in the community, pioneering innovative models, raising social awareness, and promoting the rights of people with psychosocial disabilities. The organization offers supportive housing, employment services, alternatives to hospitalization, emergency shelters for young people, counseling and direct therapy, hotlines, and more. Enosh also specializes in crisis and trauma-informed care and expanded its services to meet demand during the COVID-19 pandemic and after October 7, 2023. Its main challenges are meeting the increasing demand for services, recruiting, training, and retaining professionals, and adapting to rapidly changing community needs. Enosh has 1,500 staff members and an annual budget of around $60 million.



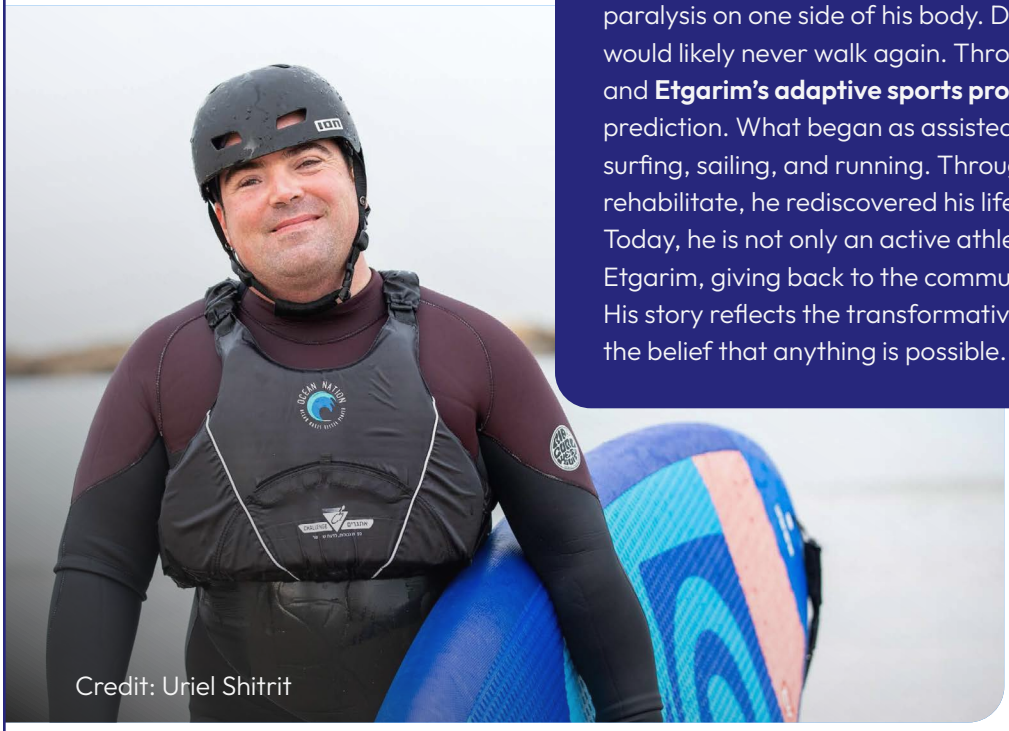
A 15-year-old girl arrived at Enosh's Balancing House for Youth in Kfar Hassidim in very poor mental condition. She was experiencing chronic depression that led to functional decline, and her parents were close to pursuing psychiatric hospitalization. Her stay at the Balancing House provided exactly what she and her family needed. She built trust with the professional team and started clinical psychological therapy. She also received a psychiatric evaluation and treatment adjustments that helped her regain stability and strength. She especially enjoyed the ceramics workshop, music therapy, and spending time in the outdoor areas of the house. After two months, she returned home with a follow-up support plan and connections to community-based services. Together with her family, she has been gradually returning to her daily routine, regaining independence.

Her parents later wrote to us: "Seeing her smiling again and full of plans for the future simply fills our hearts."

Etgarim

Etgarim's mission is to enable people with disabilities to realize their potential, overcome physical and emotional barriers, and integrate into society as equals. The organization maintains a unique framework that combines challenging outdoor experiences with personal empowerment. Etgarim was established in 1995 by IDF veterans with disabilities to provide outdoor challenge sports programs to people with a wide range of disabilities. Programs include cycling, sailing, surfing, hiking, rope courses, diving, and more and are facilitated by a large network of dedicated volunteers. The organization's main challenges are the high costs of specialized equipment and the need to scale up activities to support thousands of security personnel who were physically or mentally wounded in the recent war. Etgarim has 140 staff members and an annual budget of more than $6 million.

Amir Argaman (36) was only 18 years old when a devastating car accident left him with a life-threatening brain injury and paralysis on one side of his body. Doctors told his family he would likely never walk again. Through relentless determination and **Etgarim's adaptive sports programs**, Amir defied every prediction. What began as assisted tandem cycling grew into surfing, sailing, and running. Through sport, Amir did not just rehabilitate, he rediscovered his life, independence, and purpose. Today, he is not only an active athlete but also a staff member at Etgarim, giving back to the community that helped rebuild his life. His story reflects the transformative power of sport, support, and the belief that anything is possible.



Credit: Uriel Shitrit

Krembo Wings

Krembo Wings' mission is to create a space where children and youth with and without disabilities grow, learn, and lead together. Krembo Wings is Israel's first fully-inclusive youth movement—which means that children with severe or complex disabilities are welcomed and youth are brought together from every sector of society, including secular and religious, Jews, Arabs, Druze, and Bedouin—fostering mutual respect, resilience, and belonging. The organization sees itself as not just a youth movement, but a movement for social change, proving that diversity strengthens Israeli society when every young person has a place to belong. Krembo Wings has more than 90 branches nationally, each serving between 30-250 participants. In addition, it also runs a national service year program and helps graduates with pathways to their next opportunities. The organization's main challenges are the impact of the ongoing security and social instability in Israel, insufficient government funding due to the organizations special mandate, stigma and lack of public awareness, and high operational costs associated with working with youth of diverse abilities. Krembo Wings has 190 staff members and an annual budget of around $15 million.

Nitzan Association

Nitzan's mission is to empower children, teens, and adults with learning disabilities and attention difficulties by providing personalized educational, emotional, and social support, working in partnership with families, educators, and communities to ensure that every individual can realize their full potential. The organization works closely with the Ministry of Education and local education departments to implement its comprehensive, nationwide model focused only on learning disabilities and ADHD. It has more than 60 years of experience and 40 branches nationwide. The Association's main challenges are meeting the rising demand for diagnostic and support services, ensuring equitable access in Israel's geographic periphery, and helping children with mild and undiagnosed learning disabilities. Nitzan has 174 staff members and an annual budget of around $15 million.

Simcha Layeled

Simcha Layeled's mission is to support, empower, and accompany children, youth, and young adults with physical, sensory, or medical disabilities—but without cognitive impairments or autism—throughout their developmental journey. It develops and enhances participants' life skills, preparing them for adult life with a strong sense of capability, confidence, and independence. Simcha Layeled promotes inclusion, resilience, personal growth, and social integration through holistic and professional programs. Simcha Layeled and its volunteers work with hospitalized children in 48 pediatric hospital wards across Israel and through local branches nationally. Its main challenges are securing sustainable funding, recruiting and training skilled professionals in the geographic periphery of Israel, and retaining volunteers for extended commitments. Simcha Layeled has 64 staff members and an annual budget of around $4.5 million.

For the full organizational mapping, please click here.

Appendix: Task Force Members & Interviewees

Designated Allocations Task Force Members:

Sara Gottlieb (Toronto)
Chair, Israel & Overseas Committee

Susie Sorkin (San Francisco)
Chair, Designated Allocations Task Force

Gita Berk (Chicago)

Adam Bleznak (Detroit)

Theresa Dupuis (San Diego)

Lindsey Glantz (Broward County)

Eileen Graves (Milwaukee)

Craig Kornblum (Atlanta)

Beth Liss (Kansas City)

Risa Miller (Charlotte)

Barbara Orenstein-Present (Rochester)

Jason Reitberger (Baltimore)

Dorothy Tananbaum (New York)

The Task Force was staffed by the following Jewish Federations professionals:

Rebecca Caspi, SVP, Israel & Overseas and Director General, Israel Office

Benjamin Rutland, Managing Director, Program & Planning, Israel Office

Graeme Campbell, Director, Program & Planning, Israel Office

Task Force members and/or professionals were assisted by the expertise of the following people and organizations:

Academics, Activists, Experts: Professor Roni Holler, Professor Shirli Werner, Dr. Dorit Weshler, Dr. Nitzan Almog, Ronit Bar, Efrat Stern, Yoav Kraim, Odelia Fitoussi, Batya Leidner, Yuval Wagner, Michal Rimon, Idit Saragusti, Tali Marcus, MK Karine Elharrar, Noga Keren (Arison Foundation)

Nonprofit Organizations: Access Israel, AKIM, AlManarah, ALUT, Beit Issie Shapiro, Bizchut, Chimes Israel, Enosh, Etgarim, House of Wheels, ILAN, Israel Elwyn, Kesher - Connecting Special Families, Kivunim, Krembo Wings, The Movement for Independent Living, Nitzan, OTI, Simcha Layeled, Shalva, Shavvim, SHEKEL

Government: Ministry of Welfare and Social Affairs, Ministry of Health

Jewish Federations Colleagues: Pam Zaltsman, Suzie Patt Benvenisti, Rina Goldberg, Aaron Kaufman, Stacey Hess, Eliana Hacohen, Marketing & Creative, Impact and Growth, and Israel-based Federation representatives